

WHIDBEY ISLAND HORSE COUNCIL
MEETING MINUTES
JULY 9, 2025

The meeting was called to order at 6:15 by meeting coordinator Sally Garratt. Present were Betsy, Karena, Rhed,,Ouch, Leslie, Barb, Bruce, and Sally.

Betsy reviewed the minutes of the last meeting held on June 11, 2025. All agreed that the SWOT analysis was very good and identified areas of Strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats. Several projects were identified for the WIHC to work on during that meeting and we discussed the progress made on those projects.

Project discussion:

1. The Island County Comp plan was reviewed by Leslie who talked with a county employee (Name?) about including more horse related information in the Plan. Bruce also helped review the Comp Plan. She stated that we are concerned not just about places to ride on Whidbey but also about land use planning to allow keeping horses, boarding facilities and businesses. Leslie will submit written comments to Island County before the July 14th deadline. Leslie requested that we include in the comments the volunteer hours contributed by the Whidbey Island Trail Riders to show support in county work by riders. She also suggested that we conduct a survey of horse activities on the Island to show the economic impact of horses.
2. A Whidbey Island Horse Resource Directory is being compiled by Rhed. She described progress on the project and said that she has included many equine related contacts in the Directory such as farriers, vets, supply stores, Hay growers/sellers, boarding facilities, etc. Ouch is a new member of the Council and friend of Rhed who is helping to compile the Directory and volunteered to help with communications for the Council.
3. We discussed Rhed's library project with kids. She had over 200 people show up for the last meet/greet at the library. We agreed to support projects like that and help with the next one. We also discussed the Town Council meeting where about 13 horse lovers showed up to support having horses in Coupeville parades. Rhed explained that to do that the Mayor requires us to notify the organizers of the parade and get permission from them to be in the parade. The Coupeville Town Council members were supportive of having horses (and other animals) in any parades.
4. Leslie suggested that the WIHC adopt "Mission Statement". We agreed to put consideration of a "Mission Statement" on the agenda for the next meeting.
5. We also discussed the use of the Whidbey Equine Directory. This topic should be included in the agenda for the next meeting.
6. Barb reported that she is working with Jason at the State Parks to increase the ability of horses to ride on State Park trails. This will be an ongoing project.'

We briefly discussed the membership and leadership of the WIHC. Sally agreed to be the "Co-ordinator" who will reserve the meeting room, take notes and facilitate the meetings. We agreed that the WIHC is a self directed group working on individual projects of interest to those individuals who choose to take them on.

The next meeting of the WIHC will be **AUGUST 13, 2025** at the Race Road Firehouse 6pm-7:30pm. Meeting adjourned at 7:30pm.

